invade, the Cubans would have to meet U Thant halfway and allow UN inspection of Soviet ships in their ports. That would avoid any violation of Cuban sovereignty.

His strategy backfired. Apparently, Castro had had enough of Mikoyan's insistence on something that the Cubans had rejected again and again. In a calm tone, he told Mikoyan that they would not accept inspection of any kind: that was the will of the Cuban people. "If our position puts peace throughout the world at risk, then we would think it more correct to consider the Soviet side free of its obligations, and we will resist by ourselves. Come what may. We have the right to defend our dignity ourselves." The statement had the force of an exploding bomb. Mikoyan reported to Moscow that for a few minutes everyone was silent. Then Dorticós took the floor to say that Castro had expressed the position of the entire Cuban leadership. The earth seemed to shake under Mikoyan's feet. "I do not understand such a sharp reaction to my proposal," he told the gathering.[12]

In his report to Moscow, Mikoyan asked Khrushchev not to draw any final conclusions from the statement, suggesting that Castro did not mean what he had said and indicating his mercurial personality. "One should not forget the complicated personal qualities of Castro's character, his acute sensitivity. While in power, he made many thoughtless statements caused by a fleeting impressionability, which he later regretted." But he also concluded that if Castro accepted any form of inspection after his numerous statements opposing it, then his prestige in Cuba and Latin America generally would be undermined. What that meant in practice was that Moscow would have to forget about inspections involving Cuban territory or waters.[13]

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AFTER KHRUSHCHEV'S SURPRISE PUBLIC ANNOUNCEMENT OF the withdrawal of the Soviet missiles from Cuba the cracks in the edifice of the Soviet-Cuban alliance grew deeper and wider with every passing day. On November 7 the Soviets celebrated one of their major holidays, the anniversary of the